



Testing the limits of accent adaptation in 15-month-old infants

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Background

With brief exposure, van Heugten & Johnson (2014) find 15-month-old infants can adapt to a previously-unfamiliar accent

- This remains the **earliest demonstration** of accent adaptation, and stands in contrast to theories that abstract phonological knowledge emerges later, with greater vocabulary (Best et al., 2009; Mulak et al., 2013)

1. Can we replicate using the same voice in exposure and test?
2. Can we replicate with a change in talker (and talker gender) between exposure and test?

Method

Participants

15-month-old monolingual Canadian English-learning infants with no exposure to Australian English (AusE)

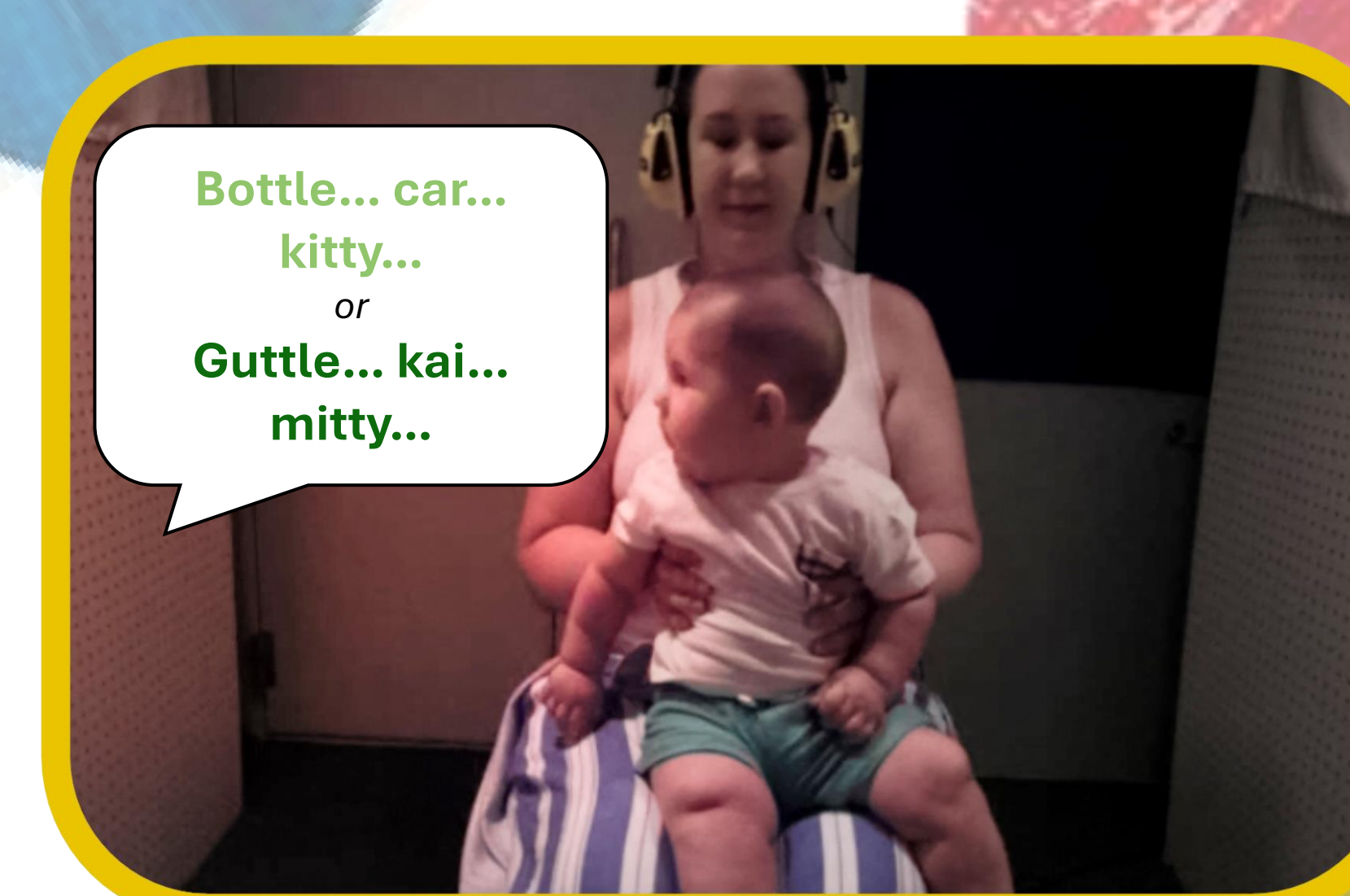
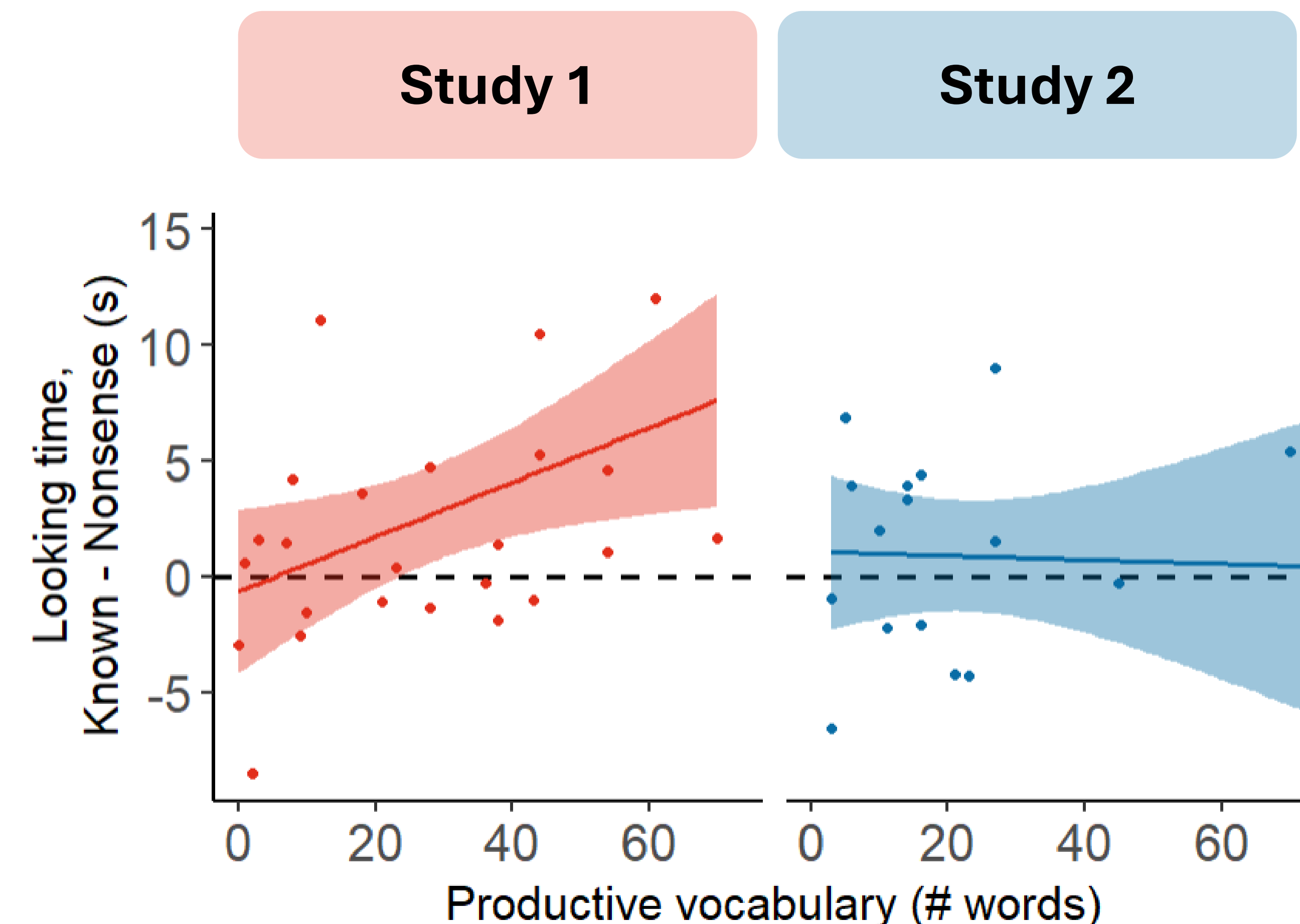
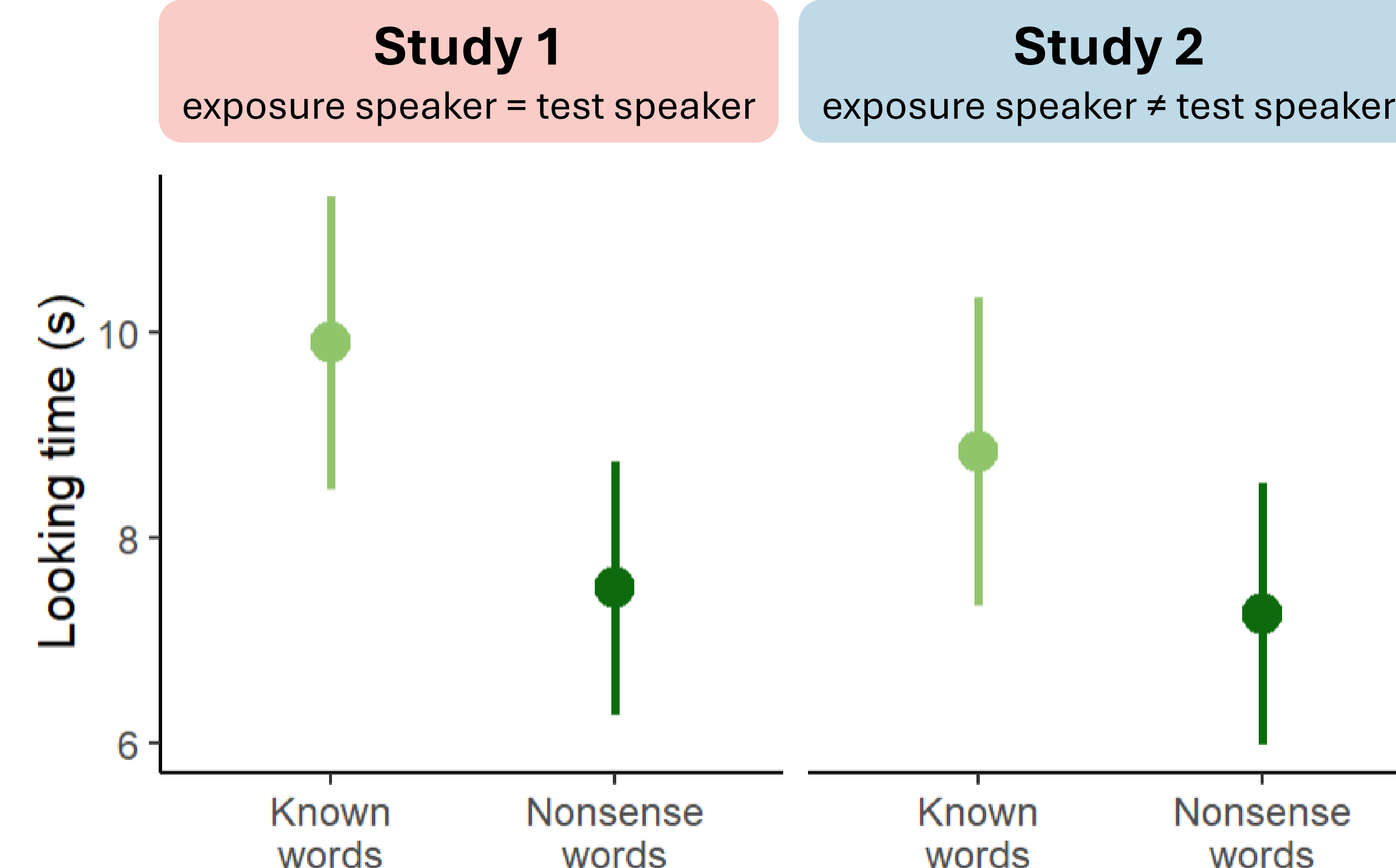
Procedure

- 1 At-home story familiarization**
Caregivers read story to infant daily for 2 weeks prior to lab visit
- 2 Brief accent exposure**
2-min video of AusE speaker reading the familiar story
- 3 Test of adaptation**
Headturn Preference Procedure (HPP) task presenting **Known Words** and **Nonsense Words** lists in AusE

	Exposure speaker	Test speaker
Study 1 ($n = 30$) <i>replication of van Heugten & Johnson (2014), Exp. 4</i>		
Study 2 ($n = 24$; planned 30)		

Vocabulary: MacArthur-Bates Communicative Development Inventory (CDI)

Results



Bottle... car...
kitty...
or
Guttle... kai...
mitti...

Discussion

- Consistent with van Heugten & Johnson (2014), **15-month-old infants adapted to a novel accent**, suggesting abstract phonological representations may be early-emerging
- Studies **differed in vocabulary** – a known correlate (e.g. Paquette-Smith et al., 2021; Mulak et al., 2013) and proposed mechanism for development of adaptation abilities, limiting interpretability of Study 2
- Future work** can test additional accents and bilingual infants

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